2

Gestures, Sign Languages, and Multimodality

Having introduced readers to linguistic anthropologists' approach to language as a form of social action, we discuss in this chapter how language is much more than just talk or words. As Jakobson's concept of multifunctionality emphasizes, linguistic interactions are always operating on multiple levels and through multiple channels. Scholars call this *multimodality*, and those who study multimodal discourse seek to understand more deeply how participants in an interaction can co-construct meanings through multiple modes (which can also be called modalities or channels) in addition to face-to-face speech, such as nonverbal gestures, gazes, facial expressions, body movements, written texts, computers, material objects, or other semiotic forms.

Consider the following example. In a classic comedy skit that appeared on "The Tonight Show" in 2013, entitled, "#Hashtag," Jimmy Fallon and Justin Timberlake proceed to have a face-to-face conversation that mimics an online exchange.[1] Throughout the interaction they liberally intersperse the word "hashtag," accompanying it with a hand gesture – two fingers of each hand overlapping each other to look like the number sign on a keyboard – whenever an online user might insert a hashtag in a post on social media. Their rapid-fire references to American popular culture are very generation- and culture-specific, so many of the jokes might be unintelligible to some audiences, but for our purposes the interesting point is that the comedy routine derives much of its humor from the

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central idea of the skit: the displacement of a linguistic feature (the hashtag) from one mode of communication (social media), where it is ordinarily used, to another (face-to-face conversation). Different modes of communication often involve different socially and culturally specific conventions of language use, and individuals who transgress those conventions may generate laughter, anger, or confusion.[2] The humor in this skit derives, at least partially, from this sort of transgression.

The "#Hashtag" skit is also a useful example in several other respects because it demonstrates how meanings can be co-constructed by participants not just through speech but through various other semiotic modes, or channels. Hearkening back to Jakobson's model representing the multifunctionality of language (see Figure 1.4 from Chapter 1), we might recall that one of the prime constituents of a speech event is the "channel," or mode, through which the interaction takes place. If we broaden our analysis beyond interactions that involve face-to-face conversation, it soon becomes clear that semiosis – or meaning making – can occur through many modes, including, for example, the following (among others):

- Speech
- Gestures and other forms of embodied communication
- Sign languages
- Whistles
- Song
- Illustrations and images
- Writing

Often, particular uses of language will involve more than one of these modes. Instances involving what linguistic anthropologists call *multimodal discourse* are more common than you might imagine; any time a person's speech is accompanied by gestures or body movements, for example, the interaction is multimodal. Before focusing in on some of these nonverbal modes of meaning-making, however, it will be helpful to present the work of two scholars, Erving Goffman and Mikhail Bakhtin, each of whom mainly worked on verbal interactions, but their theories are still quite applicable to understanding the multimodality inherent in human communication.

Bakhtin's Double-Voiced Discourse

Mikhail Bakhtin was a Russian literary critic whose wisdom about the "socially charged life of language" formed the epigraph of the first chapter of this book. Bakhtin is well known for his concept of *heteroglossia*, which refers to the multiplicity of socially tinged ways of speaking in any given society – some of high status, some low. We will return to this concept in a later chapter. For our purposes here, Bakhtin suggested another helpful term: *double-voiced discourse*. Such discourse involves the embedding of others' voices into one's own voice, either through direct or indirect quotation, or more subtly through mimicry or tone. Because he was a literary critic and not a social scientist, Bakhtin analyzed this phenomenon in the context of the novel, but it is easy to see its relevance and utility for everyday linguistic interactions. About double-voiced discourse, Bakhtin wrote,

> there are two voices, two meanings and two expressions … Double-voiced discourse is always internally dialogized. Examples of this would be comic, ironic or parodic discourse, the refracting discourse of a narrator, refracting discourse in the language of a character and finally the discourse of a whole incorporated genre – all these discourses are double-voiced and internally dialogized. A potential dialogue is embedded in them, one as yet unfolded, a concentrated dialogue of two voices, two world views, two languages. (Bakhtin 1981a:324–325)

Returning to the "#Hashtag" skit for a moment, it is clear that the humor in it depends not only on the use (or overuse) of the word and gesture "hashtag" but also relies heavily on the participants' allusions to, or direct quoting of, snippets from songs, slogans, and other popular culture sources. These are all examples of Bakhtin's double-voiced discourse and are extremely common in everyday speech. Whenever this sort of discourse takes place, echoes, associations, and even moral connotations stemming from the source of the quotation are taken up by the speaker and then presented, but usually in a refracted way. The "internally dialogized" aspect that Bakhtin mentions allows the speaker to comment upon the words being borrowed – and yet usually say nothing explicitly. In this way, entire genres can be incorporated or commented upon, much as Jimmy Fallon and Justin

Timberlake were presenting in "#Hashtag" a commentary on social media users (or at least on those who overuse hashtags).

Goffman's Participation Framework and Production Format

Some linguistic anthropologists who analyze conversations draw on the theories of Erving Goffman, a sociologist who rejected many of the most common preconceived notions – or language ideologies – regarding the ways in which conversations allegedly take place between speakers and hearers. Like Dell Hymes before him, Goffman rejected approaches that focused on isolated speakers or even isolated speaker-hearer dyads. Instead, Goffman emphasized the importance of foregrounding participation in general as an analytical concept (Goodwin 2001). Goffman recognized that there were many potential interactional roles people can inhabit, so he suggested applying a sophisticated participation framework and production format even to the simplest of conversations. He argued, for example, that we should distinguish between ratified and unratified hearers. Some hearers are addressees (those to whom the speaker addresses an utterance), but others are bystanders, overhearers, or even eavesdroppers.

Similarly, Goffman realized that the seemingly unified role of speaker in any interaction can also be separated into different roles (Goffman 1981:144):

- *Animator*. The person who serves as the voice box; the person who animates the words being spoken, whether they are the speaker's own words or not.
- *Author*. The person who composed the words, whether or not this person is the one who voices them.
- *Principal*. The person who stands behind what is said; the person whose opinions are expressed, whether or not this person composed or voiced these opinions.

In an earlier version of this well-known typology, Goffman (1986[1974]) presented a slightly different set of roles that included "emitter," for the voice box, and "animator" to represent the "expressive actions" accompanying talk, which is interesting to note with

reference to our focus on multimodality in this chapter. Other scholars have also suggested multiple alternative roles. The most important insight to glean, however, is Goffman's initial one that the dominant language ideology concerning conversations – that they involve one unified speaker and one unified hearer – is a model that is, at best, too simple and, at worst, simply incorrect.

Sometimes, all three speaker roles are inhabited by one person, but sometimes they can be distributed across several people or be relatively indeterminate (cf. Irvine 1996). So, to give a hypothetical example, let's assume that President Obama once delivered a speech that was written by a speech writer who totally disagreed with the President's policies. Let's also assume that the speech writer wrote eloquently and convincingly enough to keep his or her job. As President Obama delivered the speech, he would be considered the animator (the voice box) and, presumably, the principal (the person whose opinions are being expressed), but the speech writer would be the author – and *not* the animator or the principal. Even in ordinary conversations, these roles frequently shift, especially when reported speech is used. Goffman called these instances *shifts in footing*:

> A change in footing implies a change in the alignment we take up to ourselves and the others present as expressed in the way we manage the production or reception of an utterance. A change in our footing is another way of talking about a change in our frame for events. … [P]articipants over the course of their speaking constantly change their footing, these changes being a persistent feature of natural talk. (1981:128)

Such shifts in footing are important to study closely, as they offer scholars clues about the multifunctionality of even the most mundane of utterances. Changes in footing also often index various social identities, cultural values, attitudes, stances, or relationships. They can be triggered by subtle verbal or nonverbal moves and are tracked by all of us as a normal part of the complex multimodality that constitutes linguistic interactions.

Speech and the Analysis of Conversation

The approach advocated here is an integrative one that considers multiple modes of communication together because that is how we experience meaning-making on an everyday basis. Nevertheless, it is

useful to separate out a few key modes for analytical purposes. Speech, as the primary mode of communication in many instances, deserves special attention. Linguistic anthropologists, sociolinguists, and other scholars who study speech often refer to "talk-in-interaction" so as to emphasize the socially situated and jointly constructed nature of the speech they are analyzing.

In the 1960s and 1970s, Emanuel Schegloff, Harvey Sacks, and Gail Jefferson developed the approach known as Conversation Analysis (CA for short), and it has evolved since then into a vibrant field of study. CA practitioners focus on the sequential organization of talk as it unfolds moment by moment. They consider each utterance to be the context for the next utterance, and most CA scholars therefore believe that bringing in data from other methods such as interviews or experiments would constitute making unwarranted inferences (Mondada 2013:33–34; Sidnell and Stivers 2013).

Because the sequential nature of conversation is a key insight of CA scholars, turn-taking is one of their central concepts. The precise coordination needed for participants in a conversation to switch from speaking to listening and back again is accomplished largely unconsciously. We pick up on subtle pauses, intonation, or other prosodic features in speech such as pitch, volume, or rhythm, and most of the time use that information to switch turns in a conversation right on cue with what came to be called "no gaps, no overlaps" turn-taking (Duranti 1997:245ff; Walker 2013).

In addition to such cues, part of what enables this sort of coordination to occur are components of conversation that CA scholars have identified called *adjacency pairs*. These are sequences of two utterances spoken by two different speakers. An extremely common adjacency pair in English is, "How are you?" – with the preferred response, "Fine." A typical greeting exchange in Nepal is a bit different, however. When one meets another person, one frequently asks, "Where are you going?" The response is often a less-than-informative one: "In that direction." (Both of these adjacency pairs are perfect examples of cases in which Jakobson's phatic function predominates.)

There are many types of adjacency pairs, and they vary across languages and speech communities. Some examples include all sorts of question/answer exchanges, including offer/acceptance and offer/rejection ("Would you like to come with me?" "Sure!" or, "Do you want me to help you?" "No, thanks."). Compliment/rejection is a

fairly common (and gendered) adjacency pair in this society ("That's a lovely dress you're wearing." "Oh, it's just a rag I pulled out of the closet.").

Many other adjacency pairs can be identified, along with their culturally preferred types of responses. Dispreferred responses can be illuminating as well, such as when someone is asked an everyday "How are you?" and answers with a 30-minute litany of complaints. "Conversational trouble," as well as dysfluencies and repairs, can also be extremely interesting to investigate. By focusing so closely on everyday talk – something that many researchers have either overlooked or looked right through in order to get at the "real" data – CA practitioners have drawn attention to the complex accomplishments involved in even the most mundane conversations.

As valuable as the insights of CA are, however, the assumptions and research questions of most CA practitioners differ from those of most linguistic anthropologists.[3] CA scholars have traditionally insisted upon the autonomy of talk, therefore limiting themselves to analysis of transcripts. Moreover, their research questions have primarily pertained to the organization of talk itself. Linguistic anthropologists, in contrast, have generally utilized CA as one method among many (as described in the next chapter), and their research questions have usually focused on the intersections of linguistic interactions with broader social dynamics and cultural meanings. Alessandro Duranti (1997:266) identifies three main criticisms leveled at researchers who use only CA: (1) they are uninterested in the "larger contexts" of the conversations they analyze, even such basic aspects as the relationship between the people who are talking, or where or when the conversation took place; (2) their transcripts tend to indicate a very narrow view of "speech," omitting nonverbal interactions, changes in intonation, and other aspects of multimodal discourse to be discussed in this chapter; and (3) they are completely uninterested in what the speakers themselves might say to explain or interpret their own utterances. For these reasons, when linguistic anthropologists use CA (and many do consider it an extremely valuable approach), they combine it with other methods and contextualize the conversations they analyze far more comprehensively than strict CA practitioners do. In fact, conversation analysis, in conjunction with ethnographic methods, can provide valuable insights into many different kinds of linguistic and social practices.

There have actually been some interesting indications of a rapprochement between the two groups of scholars in recent years. Ignasi Clemente (2013) identifies three phases in the relationship between CA and anthropology:

1. a period of sharing during the 1960s and 1970s during which Schegloff, Sacks, and Jefferson and Dell Hymes, John Gumperz, and other anthropologically inclined sociolinguists were all involved in countering the Chomskyan view of linguistic competence that focused solely on syntax;
2. a second period during the 1980s and 1990s when CA came into its own as a discipline and grew apart from linguistic anthropology, which was also developing a separate set of intellectual interests, and this led to pretty fundamental disagreements between the two approaches along the lines of what constituted appropriate context, units of analysis, and the autonomous nature (or lack thereof) of conversation; and
3. a third period beginning in the early 2000s and extending to the present of reinvigorated "interdisciplinary convergence" (Clemente 2013:690) as a result of cross-fertilization and renewed dialogue between scholars in both disciplines.

For scholars who view language as a form of social action, it is easy to see why it makes sense to study actual talk closely.

Gestures and Other Forms of Embodied Communication

But talk rarely comes to us as a disembodied voice, so linguistic anthropologists who study communicative events often analyze gestures, body movements, facial expressions, and interaction with various objects (or "props") in the material environment alongside speech as an integrated, multimodal event. Meanings cannot begin to be understood – or might even be misunderstood – if such elements are left out of the analysis.

Various typologies have been suggested for the analysis of multimodal discourse. Following Enfield (2005), Stivers and Sidnell (2005) distinguish between "vocal/aural" modalities on the one hand and "visuospatial" modalities on the other, but while some scholars have found

these sorts of typologies to be useful, others, such as Haviland (2004) and Streeck et al. (2011:9), have not. These latter researchers prefer instead to focus on the integration and coordination of multiple modalities of communication within the material world rather than separating modalities apart from one another. They argue that the interaction should be understood as a complex, emergent ensemble in which the whole adds up to be more than the sum of the parts. "Insofar as gestural typologies ignore or minimize such semiotic complexity in the different gestural 'types' they isolate, the classificatory impulse seems analytically obfuscating rather than helpful" argues Haviland (2004:205).

While it is undoubtedly true that meaning-making involves multiple modalities, as well as the material environment (and, I would add, knowledge of personal histories, cultural norms, social relations, and many other invisible and inaudible aspects of the event at hand), it is still useful to take note of at least one of the gesture categorizations before presenting a few examples of analyses of emergent multimodal discourse.

Perhaps the most common typology of gestures is psychologist David McNeill's (1992:78–80):

- *Iconics* are gestures that "bear close formal relationship to the semantic content of speech" (1992:78). In other words, they iconically (in a Peircean sense) resemble that which is being described verbally. An example might be if a girl traced in the air the shape of a huge tree that she saw being cut down. A subset of *iconics* are sometimes called *emblems*, which are stand-alone gestures that have a conventional meaning within a particular society or speech community. Examples of emblems include the thumbs-up sign, giving someone "the finger," and placing the cuckold or rabbit-ears sign behind someone else's head. Emojis can also be considered emblems, given their iconic resemblance to that which they represent, as we will discuss further in Chapter 8. Each of these signs can mean different things in different speech communities around the world.[4] For example, my daughter told me several years ago that in her fifth-grade class the rabbit-ears sign meant "Turn around, I want to kiss you" – but she assures me that the recipient of the action never actually complied with this request! (See Figure 2.1.)
- *Metaphorics* are gestural representations of more abstract concepts, such as a cupped hand to represent a question. As Keith Murphy (2003:34) notes, however, these sorts of gestures also have an



Figure 2.1 A gesture with many possible meanings: "Peace," "V for victory," or "Turn around, I want to kiss you".
Source: Courtesy Laura Ahearn.

iconic component. For this reason, both *iconics* and *metaphorics* are sometimes grouped together and called *representational*.

- *Deictics* are pointing gestures – they often use the index finger and are therefore easily identified as indexical signs.
- *Beats* have no discernible meaning, according to McNeill, but instead might involve pounding of the fist or flicking of the finger to count off participants, emphasize a point, or separate sections of a narrative, for example.

Increasingly, gestures are analyzed as part of an overall embodied participation framework, revealing insights about how gestures, talk, touch, eye gaze, body movements, and the material environment all interact to create meaning. This is the approach we will take in this book – a practice-based approach, in other words, one that is

in keeping with our view of language as a form of social action. Jürgen Streeck is one of the leading theorists advocating this way of studying of gesture, which, he argues, should be conceived of "as a family of human *practices*: not as a code or symbolic system or (part of) language, but as a constantly evolving set of largely improvised, heterogeneous, partly conventional, partly idiosyncratic, and partly culture-specific, partly universal practices of using the hands to produce situated understandings" (Streeck 2009:5; emphasis in the original; cf. Farnell 2012; Goodwin and Cekaite 2018; Kataoka 2013).

When one uses this approach to study interactions, one of the main accomplishments in any linguistic interaction becomes quite clear: the establishment of a joint attentional frame and a common understanding of what the interaction is "about." Often this understanding will come not from any words that are spoken but rather from unspoken movements, gestures, or spatial configurations. It can be challenging to arrive at this joint understanding of what sort of interaction is taking place, especially when the backgrounds of participants differ – but even when they do not. Small gestures, eye gazes, or body movements can help to cue the interactional frame and appear to speed up rather than slow down the recipient's response time (Holler and Levinson 2019).

Misao Okada analyzes exactly how this sort of joint attention and understanding are arrived at in an analysis of how a Japanese boxer and his coach come to understand each other by coordinating their talk, eye gaze, gesture, body movements, and surrounding material objects (Okada 2013:391). First, as the boxer and his coach work together, they carefully track each other's movements and develop a "joint attentional frame." Then, through a complex series of words, gestures, and movements, they proceed through the session successfully because they both understand how to communicate using the multiple semiotic modalities available to them. Our ability to understand one another is based on much more than abstract knowledge of grammar, or even the ability to speak, Okada argues: "Communicative competence encompasses participants' ability to use, understand and coordinate not only talk but also a combination of other resources, such as hand gestures or body movements … A hearer's ability to attribute meaning to a speaker's intricate combination of vocal and nonvocal behaviors is necessary to attain a congruent understanding of what is going on" (Okada 2013:400).

Sometimes "what is going on" is not so congruent, however. As Barbara LeMaster demonstrates in her study of preschoolers, their nonverbal behaviors often contradict their verbal assertions. In the case of one girl named Alice, who does not agree with her teacher's choice of another student to speak next, she carries on her resistance nonverbally: "By remaining silent, Alice complies verbally with the teacher's ultimate right to choose Adam as next speaker, but she simultaneously uses her body to both reject the teacher's move and to reinforce her right to be called on next" (LeMaster 2010:170). And another student, named Herman, does the same thing: he "verbally complies with the teacher's assessment but continues the conflict nonverbally, through his posture, facial expressions, and eye gaze" (LeMaster 2010:172).

Mark Sicoli (2013, 2020) calls this type of mismatch between verbal and nonverbal messaging "intermodal discord." He provides an excellent example from a Zapotec village in Oaxaca, Mexico, where a woman who was visiting another family's home offered to do the dishes after dinner. This situation placed the hosts in a quandary because on the one hand, visitors are not supposed to do chores, and on the other hand, guests' offers are supposed to be accepted. Through a close analysis of a videotape of the interaction, Sicoli shows how the family members' verbal statements contradicted their embodied movements with regard to the dishes, enabling them to navigate this tricky social situation.

The Buddhist monks that Michael Lempert (2012) studies have a related challenge, though the context is completely different. In the Sera Monastery in India, traditional Buddhist practices surrounding monastic discipline and debate are quite pugilistic, if not outright violent. These sorts of practices can be seen to clash with "modern" Western liberal values that emphasize the language of rights, as well as with the Tibetan Buddhists' own language emphasizing universal compassion. Lempert analyzes the theatrical embodied debates alongside other data to derive a more comprehensive understanding of these monks' practices.

Eve Tulbert and Marjorie Harness Goodwin analyze intermodal discord in their comparison of several families' toothbrushing routines in the US. They identify what they call a "conjoined directive" (2011:83) – when physical and verbal actions work together to create a sense of force – for example, when a mother's series of commands

(to go, brush teeth, get dressed) are in alignment with her actions (she turns off their monitor and music video). This is in contrast to a "disjunctive directive" – when the parent's posture and actions do not align with the command to begin a new task, but rather contradict it; the force of the directive is therefore weakened (2011:84). Tulbert and Goodwin present a vivid example of the conjoined directive in one family, in which an older sister helps her 18-month-old little sister as they both brush their teeth in the bathroom while standing nestled against one another at the sink. In another family, in contrast, the disjunctive directive is illustrated when the father enters the living room holding a toothbrush. His children are watching television there, but instead of turning off the television, he puts the toothbrush in front of them on the couch and tells them to brush. A complex negotiation involving bribery and divided attention ensues, as the children refuse to brush their teeth – at least not without a reward of a cookie or piece of gum. "Clearly different types of moral actors are co-constructed through displays of reluctance and resistance, in contrast to willingness, to carry out routine courses of action" (2011:85). The processes through which children are socialized in and through language to become competent members of their cultures will be discussed at greater length in Chapter 4, but for our purposes here, it is important to note that Tulbert and Goodwin's study relied upon a multimodal analysis, which, they argue, "is absolutely essential to any study of parenting strategies" (2011:90; cf. Goodwin and Cekaite 2018).

Sign Languages

We turn now to a different type of multimodal communication, sign languages. This fascinating topic reinforces many of the concepts we have discussed in the book thus far. Unfortunately, misconceptions and negative language ideologies regarding sign languages abound, so it is necessary to debunk some common myths that people often hold about these languages (cf. LeMaster and Monaghan 2004).

Myth #1 – Sign languages are not "real" languages but instead are pidgin forms of communication with no grammar of their own. William Stokoe and other researchers have convincingly put this myth to rest. Sign languages have all the components we mentioned in Chapter 1 in

the section, "So, What Do You Need to Know in Order to 'Know' a Language?" Also, sign languages do not consist merely of fingerspelling or of crude iconic gestures that resemble that which is being described. In the case of American Sign Language (ASL), in the place of phonemes (bits of sound that make a difference in meaning), users draw upon these five parameters involving gesture and other nonverbal modalities:

- Handshape
- Location of the hand relative to the body
- Movement of the hand (or lack thereof)
- Palm orientation (up or down)
- Non-manual markers, such as facial expressions. Here we see that the whole body is important for signers, not just the hands. ASL is truly a multimodal form of expression.

A shift in any one of these parameters can change the meaning of a sign in subtle or dramatic ways. All full-fledged sign languages are just as complex grammatically as spoken languages and just as capable (or incapable) of expressing anything a user wishes to convey. The only sign languages that are exceptions to this rule are the few signing modalities that are used by hearing people under special circumstances, such as Walpiri women's signing, which they use when they are mourning (Haviland 2004:212; Kendon 1988) or Plains Standard Sign Language, which is a set of signing practices in decline but still used by some Native American groups such as the Nakota, Blackfoot, Cheyenne, Kiowa, and Arapaho (Farnell 1995). These are rich linguistic practices, but unlike ASL and other sign languages, most are not equipped with a comprehensive set of syntactic and semantic features.

Myth #2 – Sign Languages are basically iconic; that is, they are made up of gestures that look like what they are representing. While some signs have iconic elements, they are also combined with conventional (or symbolic) aspects – just like spoken languages, which have iconic signs in the form of onomatopoeic words such as "choo choo" or "cockadoodledoo" that are conventionally understood within particular speech communities. (In Nepal, for example, roosters say "kukhurikwā" instead of "cockadoodledoo.") Now that people

generally do not view signers anymore as simply "painting pictures in the air" but rather as expressing themselves via a fully formed human language, more scholars are beginning to study the complex types of iconicity and multimodality found in sign languages (e.g., Cates et al. 2013). This kind of research has the potential to teach us a lot, not just about sign languages but about linguistic interactions in general.

Myth #3 – Sign language is universally shared by all deaf people in the world. This is simply untrue. Many deaf people do not use any sign language at all, either from choice or from lack of access. Ethnologue.com lists 144 deaf sign languages in the world as of February 2020, but these are only the ones that have been documented by scholars, and many of these are endangered (e.g., Nonaka 2014). It is estimated that there are several hundred sign languages in total, and there are most likely many more registers or dialects, such as Black ASL (The Language and Life Project 2020). While the domain of a sign language will often coincide with a particular spoken language or nation, there need not be any linguistic relationship between the sign language and a geographical area's spoken language. For example, ASL is much closer linguistically to French Sign Language than to British Sign Language because of the history of how it was developed – and it is very different grammatically from spoken English. As another example, in Nepal, there is one national sign language and at least three "village" sign languages (cf. Hoffman-Dilloway 2008).

Myth #4 – There are no distinctive social or cultural practices associated with speaking particular sign languages. Because 90% of deaf people are born to hearing parents, they generally learn sign language in school settings. Within these speech communities, distinctive social and cultural practices have sprung up. Some ASL users, for example, prefer to capitalize the word "Deaf" and refer proudly to "Deaf culture" as a distinctive way of life that is complete with poetry, theater, distinctive expressions and interactional practices, etc. (In this case, we could say that the capital "D" indexes a cultural identity.) The controversy between individuals who advocate operating on deaf children to insert cochlear implants to improve their hearing enough to be able to lip read and individuals who do not support cochlear implants is at least as much about culture as it is about language.

A great deal can be learned about the human capacity for language in general and about specific communities of language users by studying sign languages. New sign languages continue to emerge, either in the context of deaf communities such as schools, as in the case of Nicaraguan Sign Language (Coppola 2002; Coppola and Senghas 2010; Senghas 2003), or in the context of families or communities where a large number of people are deaf for genetic reasons. The Al Sayyid Bedouin Sign Language is such a "village sign language" (Sandler et al. 2014). These new sign languages enable researchers to study how children acquire language, whether signed or spoken, and produce insights into interactions between deaf and hearing people, as well as into multimodal discourse more generally.

Poetry, Whistled Languages, Song, and Images

There are many other modalities through which meaning can be conveyed and co-constructed; it is impossible to describe all of them. One major one – writing, including computer-mediated communication and other forms of literacy – will be the focus of a later chapter. In the final section of this chapter, therefore, let me just mention a few more of the semiotic modalities that linguistic anthropologists study.

Poetry, both in the formal sense of poems written by poets, and in the Jakobsonian sense of the poetic potential of all utterances, deserves more attention than it usually receives from scholars. Arguments, marketing slogans, and even everyday remarks may contain poetic features such as alliteration, parallelism, rhythm, prosody, and the like, which can make them more or less effective or memorable. Linguistic anthropologists such as Dell Hymes, Paul Friedrich, Dennis Tedlock, Anthony Webster, and other contemporary researchers have shed light on the underlying poetic features of all discourse in a field called *ethnopoetics* (cf. Kataoka 2012). Webster (2009, 2015), for example, explores the politics and sentiments behind the language choices that young Navajos make and the role that poetry plays in these decisions, looking particularly closely at how individuals invest languages with what Sapir (1921:40) called "feeling-tones." Webster's research reveals the microprocesses of language ideologies at work, demonstrating how "intimate grammars" and emotions cause linguistic forms to "come to be icons of identity – icons that are

deeply felt, but that can be evaluated negatively by outsiders" (Webster 2010:187; cf. Povinelli 2006).

Another semiotic modality that is available to most human speakers is the whistle. In some environments, such as rain forests, or mountainous regions with dense vegetation, the local language is converted into a whistled form of communication. Unlike the sign languages mentioned earlier, whistled languages are based directly on spoken languages but usually cannot convey the full range of meanings of those spoken languages. Still, whistled languages (or "whistled speech") can communicate a fairly wide range of information. Like many sign languages, however, many whistled languages, such as Silbo Gomero, a whistle language used in the Canary Islands, Spain, and the Sochiapam Chinantec whistled language of Oaxaca, Mexico, are endangered because very few young people are learning how to use them. Some scholars (e.g., Meyer 2015 and Sicoli 2012) are attempting to document these languages through scholarly articles and popular videos (e.g., "Speaking in Whistles: The Whistled Language of Oaxaca, Mexico"[5]) before they disappear so that we – and the communities that use these languages – can learn about and potentially revitalize this fascinating mode of communication.

Like whistling, song can either accompany or replace speech, and it is also related in interesting ways to poetry and performance, which we will discuss at greater length in Chapter 9. Song is beyond the scope of this chapter, but it is important to note that musical modalities – everything from humming to beating out messages on the drums to playing instruments in a jazz band – are all semiotic modalities that deserve close analysis alongside talk, gesture, and other embodied communication. Oxbury, for example, analyzed a conversation among three sisters in which they broke into song periodically (Oxbury 2020), showing how the singing promotes solidarity and restores affiliation among the sisters at moments of trouble. And Harkness (2014) studied the relationship between voice, body, religion, and identity through participant observation in a Korean church choir (2014). In addition, from the perspective of another discipline, ethnomusicology is a field of study that draws upon and contributes to linguistic anthropology in fascinating ways, and vice versa (e.g., Black 2008; Duranti and Burrell 2004; Faudree 2013; Feld and Fox 1994; Samuels 2006).

Illustrations and images constitute yet another semiotic modality. Sometimes, illustrations supplement talk, as Green (2014) notes in her research on "sand stories," which are narratives that are told by aboriginal people who live in Central Australia. As they tell their stories, they trace out images in the sand on the ground. In sand stories, Green writes, "Speech, sign, gesture, and drawing are deeply intertwined" (2014:3). Another example of a multimodal analysis of images, text, and speech is Feng's (2019) study of the posters associated with Xi Jinping's "Chinese Dream" political slogan and campaign. Once we start paying attention, it becomes obvious that illustrations and all sorts of images, either created by the speakers themselves or simply referenced by them during the event, are woven into many interactions and are therefore an important semiotic modality. Here are just some examples:

- Friends pass their phones back and forth to look at photos they took at a recent party.
- A person sketches out a quick diagram on a piece of paper of the layout of rooms in a house.
- Co-workers huddle together around a computer as they try to create an effective infographic for the data that their research group has produced.
- A young child draws a picture of herself with curly hair as she signs her name on a birthday card for her grandmother.
- Staff members at Studio Ghibli, an animation film studio in Tokyo, share drafts of a storyboard for their new anime.

We will be discussing literacy practices in much greater depth in Chapter 7, so for now it is sufficient merely to flag the presence of illustrations and other sorts of images as a modality that should not be overlooked when analyzing interactions.

Oftentimes, the very mode through which one chooses to communicate conveys a message in and of itself. Ilana Gershon (2010) discovered this in her study of the different ways that people use various kinds of social media to break up romantic relationships. If one's boyfriend texts, "It's over," the modality of text messaging sends a very different message right from the start compared to the same words communicated over the phone or in person (or Facebook, e-mail, or

some other form of writing) – or the lack of any words at all, which is what happens with ghosting when a person simply drops out of touch. Gershon uses the term *media ideologies* to talk about these differences – but we could also simply view the ideas that people have about various semiotic modalities as forms of language ideologies (cf. Gershon and Manning 2014).

So to conclude this chapter, we can see language is not just multifunctional, as Jakobson reminded us, but also multimodal. Therefore, interactions should be analyzed as integrated and embodied multimodal practices because even in the most mundane of interactions such as toothbrushing routines, meanings are conveyed and co-constructed by participants by means of multiple modes, potentially including, for example, speech, gesture, touch, eye gaze, prosody, song, poetry, whistling, whispering, and illustration. People may hold language ideologies about which of these modes should be used, or what it means in particular instances to combine one with another. This is because the different semiotic modalities can index different social identities, moral stances, or subtle opinions on various issues. All four of our key terms – multifunctionality, language ideologies, practice, and indexicality – can therefore be brought to bear on this topic.